

Appendix: Professional Word Banks

for Early Childhood Observation Documentation

Having Tough Conversations with Families of Children Who Require Additional Support

How to use this appendix: These word banks provide professionally framed, objective language to support accurate observation and documentation. Choose words that describe what you directly see or hear. Avoid words that label, judge, or diagnose. When in doubt, ask: 'Could I describe exactly what I observed that led me to choose this word?' If yes — it belongs in your notes.

This appendix includes word banks for:

1. Observable Behaviors & Actions
2. Social-Emotional Development
3. Communication & Language
4. Sensory Inputs (What the Environment Offers)
5. Sensory Responses & Outputs (How the Child Responds)
6. Attention & Learning
7. Physical & Motor Development
8. Transition & Routine Responses
9. Peer Interaction
10. Adult Interaction & Response
11. Emotional Expression
12. Strengths & Positive Descriptors
13. Strategies & Supports
14. Documentation Phrases & Sentence Starters